

Ceremony to Bless the Stupa — June 26th 2011

— Pt 3

Bhante Bodhidhamma · YouTube Talks · 36:34

Now, welcome to everyone. A wonderful day and a wonderful occasion. This being the fourth anniversary of the founding of the Satipanya Buddhist Retreat Centre. We're privileged today to have three speakers to give us the benefits of their Dharma wisdom. Perhaps we could express our appreciation after each talk in the usual Buddhist way with *sādhū*.

First of all, I'd like to ask the venerable Bodhidhamma to introduce our guests.

It was all very formal, wasn't it? Can you hear me through that or can you hear me like this?

I'd like to—some of you were here for the opening, so you'll remember Venerable Premasiri, who is one of our chief monks from Sri Lanka, and he has a lovely monastery called Sumati Pāla. It's right next to Khandavoda Meditation Centre, where Venerable Piyananda Thera is the chief monk. So these two venerables came over last time for the opening. So it's great that they've come again. That's my connection. This is the order that I personally belong to.

Then there's Venerable C.E. Dhammaloka. He is the chief monk at the Chiswick Buddhist Vihāra. So if you're ever in London, do feel free to drop in and do some meditation.

This is Roshi Saito. He's the abbot of the temple. He's an incumbent of the Telford Buddhist Priory. He's part of the establishment of Throssel Hole Abbey, which is up in Northumberland. That's his connection with me, because that's where I started with my Buddhist practice.

This is Venerable Kassapa. He's been a very long time monk, lived mainly in Sri Lanka. He's now beginning to live in the West, and hopefully he'll find himself a permanent place to stay.

Then there's Venerable Berault, who's a senior monk from Shasta Abbey. Shasta Abbey is the mother house of all the other houses to do with the Zen Buddhist tradition that was begun by Roshi Kennett, who some of you might know. Roshi Kennett wrote probably a spiritual classic on "How to Grow a Lotus Blossom"—highly recommended.

Then there's Venerable Nāgasena. Nāgasena is a resident monk in Birmingham Buddhist Vihāra. The connection I have with that is, of course, my teacher was there, Venerable Dr. Rewatadhamma, who died a few years ago.

And the Sister Candrasiri, I'm sure many of you know Sister. She's a chief nun, one of the chief nuns from

Amaravati. I'm very pleased that she's come. Could have a long association with Sister, even though she might not know it. Because way back when they were doing Chithurst, which was then a wreck, I used to go along and wash pots and do things like that. I remember generally getting on her nerves because I was doing them too quick. I remember that.

Then there's Sister Tissara. She's also living at Amaravati and is a nun of the same order. We have a little connection there because she began her Buddhist practice at Gaia House, where I was the resident teacher at the time.

Then there's Sister Puññanandī, who has ordained in the Burmese tradition of temporary ordination. I think she'll escape the order in about a day or two. But hopefully she'll get back in in the fullness of time. Some of you know, well, in her past life, she was called Noreen. She teaches occasionally at Satipānya.

Then we have Sister Ruth. Sister Ruth is also—she's an Anglican nun ordained with the Archbishop of Canterbury and is the spiritual director of a particular trust under his name. She also holds a lineage through Gary Roshī, Roshī John Gary, and therefore carries with her these two traditions, both the Buddhist tradition of Chan, Chinese Chan, and the Christian tradition. So she's right at the interface where these two monoliths appear. She lives as a hermit up on the Brecon Beacons, and she was stuck for two months in the last snow down here, but with a tractor to feed her. Wasn't it two months? Five weeks. About two months.

Then there's Father Silouan. Father Silouan just lives across here on the Stiperstones. Those of you who come from around here will know that. He's an Orthodox monk and he's been up there for many years and obviously a great companion for me. He's up there also working and I'm trying to get escape work down here so it's an opportunity to get together.

Sister Karen is also an Anglican nun and is a student of Father Silouan. She used to live very close here, that you might know, down in Bishop's Castle, but has now moved to a glorious place over towards the coast.

And then there's Caroline. Caroline Jones is a teacher at Gaia House, and for three months of the year, she occupies the position that I had there for four years. So it's really heartwarming to find somebody here who represents Gaia House and the whole lay tradition of teachers.

So those are our guests. Well, I delivered it very well, don't you think? You didn't pay heed to my request.

Now we'd like to invite Bhante Premasiri to give us a talk, a Dharma talk.

Reverend Bhikkhu Bodhidhamma. Is it? Yes. Mahāsaṅgha. Dignitaries of the various denominations and distinguished guests. I was asked to speak a few words about the meditation by Reverend Bhikkhu Bodhidhamma.

Meditation is a very easy thing to perform. People think that it's a very difficult thing to perform. It has

become difficult because they think it is difficult. You have certain aims in your life. So you tend to drop all the main aims in your life at certain times. So always try to live with not the main aim but the aims that are not important. The main aims are that you have to eat, drink, you have to go to toilet, washrooms, you have to sleep, and etcetera. These are the main goals of your aims of your life.

You can look at these things with wisdom. So you look at these activities with wisdom. So you can perform the other balance after that. So therefore, meditation is not a difficult activity to perform. A person who lives eight years starts within about ten minutes. So if you start ten minutes a day, so how long you have been meditating during your time of eighty years? Almost then, eighty years. So if you multiply your eight years into ten minutes, how long you have been meditating then? So you have to practise this.

So Bhikkhu Bodhidhamma, Reverend Bhikkhu Bodhidhamma may teach you a better way. The ten minutes that you are going to stay with meditation or meditate, you have to just forget the past. Give up your past. You give up your future. You give up your clinging or the attachment. You don't keep on thinking or contemplating. You don't have any hopes or wishes. You should not perform slowly. You should not start fast.

So if you can get rid of yourself with these eight points, so you can reach *nibbāna* soon. What reverend says is to just forget your past, drop your future and try to be in the present. So time to come, then you can just drop your present also. There is no present in the world. That's all.

Yes? Any question? No, no. Brian knows it all. Oh, absolutely.

And now we'd like Bhante Piyananda to give us a Dharma talk. Thank you, Bhante.

Sādhu, sādhu, sādhu. The incumbent of London Buddhist Vihāra. The sisters. Members of the various denominations. Distinguished guests who participate in this ceremony.

I'm very happy to state here for the invitation that you extended to participate at this occasion by the Bhikkhu Bodhidhamma and the supporters of this place. I can remember the day that the foundation stone was laid at this place. It is obvious that Bhikkhu Bodhidhamma had taken a lot of pains to improve this place during the last four years. He has performed a difficult task in a place where the Buddhism do not exist to that extent.

Today we unveil a pagoda, which is a very important monument Buddhism is concerned. Especially countries like Burma, Sri Lanka, the pagoda is revered and given much importance. The constructing of *stūpas* had taken place with the first visit of Buddha to Sri Lanka. Later, this became one of the most important sites in pagodas, sites in the Buddhist vihāras. That is because it symbolises Buddha, Lord Buddha. At the latter stage, this was the—this has become a symbol of what you follow up to *Nibbāna* and ultimate goal, the *Nibbāna*.

There are various types of pagodas in these countries. I will now tell you very concisely. It is a pagoda in

the shape of a heap of grain, in the shape of a bubble, in the shape of a bell, and in the shape of a bell. Like this, I think Sri Lanka has more importance than any other country in the world. In particular, Bodhidhamma Mahāthera, who was our teacher, has explained the pagoda of Anurādhapura in a new way. I think he has explained Anurādhapura in a way that is unique to this country.

The pagoda that Bhikkhu Bodhidhamma has constructed gives a new version to these pagodas. Because both of them have endeavoured to display by the dark circle the beings who are suffering with *avidyā* or the ignorance. The white circle, you would have seen the white circle out of the dark circle. The Bhikkhu Bodhidhamma had endeavoured to explain, saying, people who have gone forth with the Triple Gem, and who are with the *sammādiṭṭhi* here, or the correct view.

After that, you get at the foot of the pagoda, there are three circles that denotes the Buddha, Dhamma, Saṅgha. Then you can see—or rather I should call a bell-shaped, am I correct? A bell-shaped pagoda, which you may find difficult to tread on, and it displays the Five—Eight Noble Paths. If you can tread on this Eightfold Noble Path, the way that Bhikkhu Bodhidhamma has displayed, then I have no doubt you can reach *Nibbāna*. So that is what we unveil today.

So he has established this place. By that, he—stability. Stability. Yes, stability. We presume that because of Bodhidhamma, these endeavours will establish the permanency to this Satipānya retreat centre.

So we all, the Saṅgha, Mahāsaṅgha, wish that you all live peace, prosperity and happiness and that you will ultimately reach the goal that you hope to. So may all of you all be blessed.

And now we'd like to ask Sister Candrasiri to give us a few words, thank you.

It's a very great privilege to be here today and I'm really enjoying the fact that there are so many of you and from so many different cultures and backgrounds. This is one of the most exciting things I think about Buddhism at this time, that it's drawing people who've grown up in a Buddhist culture and also many people who've been drawn by the teachings about suffering and about the ending of suffering. That's certainly what drew me.

I have to confess that I wasn't really very interested in devotional practices when I first became a nun. I loved the teachings, I loved the meditation, and I loved the possibility of liberation from suffering. That certainly kept me going for a long time.

However, Venerable Bodhidhamma asked if I would say a few words about devotion this afternoon. Over the years, I've come to have a very strong sense of devotion myself and also to see the great value of this.

The devotion has arisen out of a sense of having contemplated the life of the Buddha. I found actually, strangely enough, the biggest thing for me was actually learning about the Buddha's experience with the monks and nuns, and how the discipline was established. There are some very remarkable stories about the things that the monks and nuns got up to, and there's a real sense of appreciation of the Buddha's

brilliance in the way he established the order of the monastic community and the relationship between the lay community and the monastic community. He created a situation where many, many people could benefit. That brought great joy to my heart when I contemplated that. I thought there's no way I could think up such a wonderful social system.

Thinking about the benefits of devotion and why it's a wonderful occasion for us here together to be together, one of the things I realised as having grown up in a Western culture is that I have a very critical mind. Also I have quite a strong tendency to be an individual. I tend to think of myself as being rather special and rather important. I can suffer enormously because of maybe not being quite good enough, not being quite special enough. There are all kinds of ways that I can cause myself suffering.

These occasions for devotion invite us to go beyond that self-centredness, self-preoccupation. They invite us to contemplate the possibility of liberation, the possibility of liberation from selfishness, from foolishness, to be lifted, to be carried by each other. When we perform the circumambulation of the *stūpa*, when we chant the *suttas*, we join together in recollecting the teachings, in celebrating the fact of the Buddha and his enlightenment. Something happens in the heart. It's not a rational thing, but there's a sense of being nourished, a sense of joy can arise, a sense of letting go and just entering into something altogether.

Spiritual training is not easy. Those of you who've come here for retreats, I'm sure have found it wonderful in the end, but I imagine that maybe the beginning, and certainly the middle, may have been quite difficult. It's at times like that that these practices of devotion can really help us to go beyond, to recollect our possibility, our capacity for liberation, can keep us going, can keep us treading the path.

So I encourage you to—and I'd really just like to celebrate the fact that we have this place here in Britain, a place that we can come to, that we can come and pay homage to the Buddha, the Dhamma, the Saṅgha, and contemplate the teachings, contemplate this possibility that each one of us has to free the heart from all suffering. It takes a bit of effort, it takes a lot of encouragement, but I would like to just encourage everybody to, having come here, maybe for the first time, maybe you've been coming for many, many years, just to keep coming, to keep treading the path, and may you all experience perfect liberation, may we all experience perfect liberation from all *dukkha*, which is what the Buddha has promised us that we are capable of. So let's not forget that.

Can we have one or two volunteers just to hand these little presents out to the monks? One or two volunteers?

Finally, I'd like to ask Dr Sita Sriwadana, who has been our chairman of the Trust since it was founded, to say a few words.

You're going to turn it up. If you can't hear, please tell me. I'm going to try without the mic. Okay?

Venerable sirs and friends in the Dhamma, it is with great pleasure and a sense of pride that I welcome

you all here today on behalf of Bhante Bodhidhamma and all the trustees of the Satipānya Trust. I'd like to thank you all for joining us in this ceremony.

We are especially happy that our two senior monks, Venerable Premasiri and Venerable Piyananda were able to come from Sri Lanka to officiate. And to Venerable Dhammaloka, head of the London Buddhist Vihāra and to representatives and the nuns from Amaravati and representatives of all other religious denominations here. Thank you all. A warm welcome.

Even though this is a small spiritual enterprise, you would be surprised at the number of people who have been involved in the past ten years since the Trust was founded. The list is so long, and for fear of favour, I shall only mention the three persons who were crucial to this day. Firstly, Roy Griffiths, who did all the groundwork and set up the base of the *stūpa*. I wonder if I can ask you to raise your hand, Roy? Well, he's disappeared. Then there's Gary Higgins, a master stonemason who built the *stūpa*. Can you raise your hand, Gary? And Archie Kennedy, who fashioned the reliquary but was unable to be here today.

In our custom, we say thank you by joining our hands together and saying *sādhū* three times. Can we say *sādhū*? *Sādhū. Sādhū. Sādhū.*

We have progressed a great deal from our small beginnings in April 2007, when this property was purchased. It has been extensively repaired and upgraded. On 30 June 2007, the formal opening ceremony of this retreat took place, which was attended by senior Buddhist monks from Sri Lanka and London, by well-wishers, by supporters and members of the local community.

Retreats have been conducted here from that time. The retreat programme is open to all, including the general public. Its aim is to integrate *vipassanā* meditation practice into ordinary daily life. Don't worry, it's only another page. There are also opportunities to study Buddhism and to benefit from periods of calm, reflection and contemplation. Further opportunities are available to test the monastic life for both men and women.

We have already had three men who have experienced this and I believe two women are next to do so.

Today marks the culmination of the construction of the *stupa* by placing the reliquary on it. The stupa varies slightly in shape in different countries of the world. I think the Rev. Piyananda is trying to explain to you about that. But the basic form is based on an inverted bowl. This stupa is built of Welsh slate in keeping with the surroundings.

Stupas house Buddhist relics and that is why we are here today to place a reliquary which has the Buddhist relics and a DVD of all the Buddhist scriptures on the stupa and thus complete it. We are pleased to have done all this work in four years, and I invite all of you to make more use of this center in such peaceful surroundings.

Our future plans are to make the center accessible to wheelchair users, and at the same time, extend the

area for walking meditation, and also provide space for formal retreatants. We appeal to you to help us with this project.

Finally, I hope you have all had a peaceful and uplifting day. On behalf of Bhante and the trustees, I wish you all a long and healthy life and a safe journey home. Thank you.

It's now 3.45 and it's time for tea. Thank you all for coming. Thank you.

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